Shanan and Muhammadans—are innumerable.'[78] The Bank of Madras and the National Bank of India—both European—had branches in Tuticorin. (It would take more than two decades before the South Indian Bank, the Quilon Bank, the Indian Bank and the City Bank would establish their branches.) Neither the Tuticorin Chamber of Commerce, established in 1906, nor the club on the seafront permitted non-European membership.

There were British Indian hotels and government rest houses in Tuticorin. First- and second-class board and lodging was quite expensive—as much as Rs 4-8-0 and Rs 3-0-0 respectively for a day at the turn of the century. Less than 2 km from the railway station, in Melur, there were three hotels, all run by Brahmins. As eating-houses run by Brahmins, while all castes could partake of the food, these establishments had a reserved section for Brahmins where others could not set their eyes on the food and thus 'pollute' it. A choultry (a free traveller's inn), also for Brahmins, provided free meals and provisions to the more orthodox who preferred to cook their own meals. There were nearly two dozen small hotels in the vicinity of the station to service non-Brahmins. A choultry funded by a local fund provided three days of free lodging for all castes.[79] As we shall see, these establishments played a key role in the competition between the Swadeshi company and BI, soliciting and guiding passengers. That some overenthusiastic hotelkeepers ended in jail for supporting the Swadeshi company is a story for later. *Jutka* (horse-drawn carts) and carriages, lined up near the railway station, were not cheap—they charged about half a rupee per mile.[80]

As we saw above, BI entered Tuticorin with its vast resources, administrative experience and proximity to the colonial government. BI steamers were regular: at the time of our story, they left Tuticorin at 5 p.m. daily (including Sundays) and arrived at Colombo at 8 a.m., the next day. Rather conveniently, 'Steamers are met at Colombo by tenders belonging to hotels which convey passengers and their luggage ashore.' On their daily return voyage to Tuticorin, BI steamers left at 6 p.m. and arrived at 7 a.m. the following day. While at Colombo, the passengers were to make their own arrangements to board the steamer (for which rates were fixed), at